

Discipline Yourself So No One Else Has To: Discipline Should Be Consistent, Featuring Teela Jackson

Teela Jackson, Vice President, HR

Pat said, "Discipline is all about structure. It is the bare-bones architect of your organization -- the beams and joists that hold everything together. Maintaining the integrity of your interior philosophy is crucial, even if it costs you a valued member of the team. Otherwise, your structure will collapse."

It's important to remember that discipline is not something you wield on others for your own personal empowerment. It's not something that should be inflicted capriciously, either.

In the right hands, discipline is simply a tool for fostering organizational success. It provides conviction to a philosophy. Really, discipline is just a way of getting people to cooperate with each other. You agree to obey a set of predetermined regulations so that you can all work together toward success. When you are self-disciplined, you hold yourself to high standards. Self-discipline is respect-based, while punishment is fear-based.

When discipline is administered fairly, firmly, and consistently, you bring structure and clarity to the team and the organizational environment. Pat would jokingly say, "You kill the monster before it grows." Coach Summitt wanted her players to know the rules and the consequences right up front, so they knew what was coming if they tried to sneak around a rule or consciously break one.

Pat also wanted her players to believe that if they did try to hide an infraction -- if they broke curfew or missed class -- she would know. She believed that great coaches, as well as great managers, worked diligently to see all and know all. By making it blatantly clear that actions have consequences, and though you have a choice about your actions, the consequences are automatic, non-negotiable, and mandatory. No exceptions.

Self-discipline is enduring and habitual. It removes the need for external discipline. Self-discipline, simply put, means you exemplify genuine integrity, which is doing the right thing when no one else is watching.

Pat said, "People who exercise self-discipline have an effect on everyone around them. They are tremendously influential in motivating their coworkers and colleagues. Conversely, undisciplined people can have a lousy influence."